



Research Paper

How 'social' are destinations? Examining European DMO social media usage

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ABSTRACT

This study explores how European DMOs use social media to promote and market their destinations and extends extant research on social media in tourism by: (1) using a larger sample size of 50 European countries, (2) including two additional social media platforms (*Instagram* and *YouTube*) to current investigations that commonly focus on *Facebook* and *Twitter*, (3) extending the scope of measures used in the content analysis, and (4) investigating social media platforms over a longer time period of a full year. Content analysis of measures used to examine European DMO social media usage revealed seven categories: (1) *content*, (2) *major theme*, (3) *information type*, (4) *engagement*, (5) *interactivity*, (6) *promotion* and (7) *customer service*. Based on content analysis of a systematic random sample of 3546 social media postings, results clearly indicate that social media is of interest to European DMOs. Among all European destinations, Turkey, Finland, Ireland, Netherlands and Spain were found to have a higher level of engagement, whereas France, Cyprus, Russia, Luxembourg and Norway were found to be more interactive. Findings suggest that European DMOs utilize social media as a traditional marketing tool, rather than exploiting it as a customer service tool to mitigate potential customer problems.

1. Introduction

In today's highly competitive travel market, destinations are adding digital tools to their traditional marketing practices to attract visitors. In recent years, social media has emerged as a powerful and low-cost marketing tool with global reach. Although social media platforms have demonstrated a reciprocal and growing interest in the tourism industry (Chan & Denizci Guillet, 2011; Gretzel, Fesenmaier, Formica, & O'Leary, 2006; Xiang & Gretzel, 2010), tourism research on the use of social media remains limited. Comprehensive review studies focusing on social media in tourism and hospitality have identified this research gap (e.g. Leung, Law, van Hoof & Buhalis, 2013; Zeng & Gerritsen, 2014). Extant research on the use of social media in tourism has focused mainly on the: (1) use of social media by tourists (user/tourist-generated content) and (2) adoption of social media practices by tourism enterprises. Hence, the type and extent of social media use by destination marketing organizations (DMOs) responsible for the marketing and management of tourism in particular geographic areas, remains largely unknown (Munar, 2012). Research on how DMOs use social media to market their destinations is limited (Dwivedi, Yadav, & Venkatesh, 2011; Feng, Morrison, & Ismail, 2003; Hays, Page, & Buhalis, 2013; Mariani, Di Felice, & Mura, 2016; Munar, 2012;

Stankov, Lazić, & Dragičević, 2010). One of the pioneer studies in this area was carried out by Hays et al. (2013).

In their exploratory study, Hays et al. (2013) investigated social media usage among DMOs of the top 10 most-visited countries by analyzing the content of their *Facebook* pages and *Twitter* accounts. Results revealed that the usage of social media among top DMOs was still largely experimental and that further research, with a larger sample size, was needed. In response to this call for additional research, the present study aims to fill a sizeable gap in the literature and extends previous studies in several ways. First, this study uses a larger sample size (50 European countries) and applies a random sampling method for relevant social media postings to achieve greater generalizability. Second, unlike much of the previous research, the present study includes two additional social media platforms (*Instagram* and *YouTube*) in the investigation along with the commonly examined *Facebook* and *Twitter*. Third, this study contributes to the measurement of social media research by extending the scope of measures used by Hays et al. (2013) for the content analysis. Finally, to assure more comprehensive insight into DMO use of social media, the present study covers a longer time period of a full year (2015). The broad purpose of this study is to investigate DMO usage of social media in European countries.

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2. Social media usage in tourism

Social media have fundamentally altered the way society creates and disseminates information (Buhalis & Law, 2008; Xiang & Gretzel, 2010), thereby changing both the demand (i.e. consumer decision process) and supply (i.e. marketing/management practices for businesses/organizations) sides of the tourism industry.

For travelers, social media has become a critical information source (Amaro, Duarte, & Henriques, 2016; Hudson & Thal, 2013; Zeng & Gerritsen, 2014), which is understandable since tourism products are usually considered highly risky purchases (Kim, Qu, & Kim, 2009) because they cannot be evaluated prior to consumption (Schmallegger & Carson, 2008). Therefore, new and emerging sources of information (i.e. social media) are used to minimize risks of making wrong travel decisions (Leung, Schuckert & Yeung, 2013). Traveler use of social media occurs before, during, and after the trip. In the pre-trip phase, travelers use social media to search for potential destinations, transportation options, accommodations as well as leisure activities available at the destination (Cox, Burgess, Sellitto, & Buultjens, 2009). During this phase, travelers exhibit passive participation rather than creating their own content on social media (e.g. reviews, recommendations). During the trip, travelers' use of social media appears to decrease, compared with the pre-trip phase (Cox et al., 2009); however, their participation becomes more active through content creation (e.g. user generated). More specifically, travelers begin to share their own travel experiences by uploading visual content (i.e. photos, videos) (Munar & Jacobsen, 2014). Travelers' use of social media reaches a peak during the post-trip phase (Fotis, Buhalis, & Rossides, 2012). Upon returning home, travelers generally use social media to share their personal recommendations and level of satisfaction or dissatisfaction regarding the trip through reviews, comments, photos, videos, or audios (Amaro et al., 2016; Leung, Law, van Hoof, & Buhalis, 2013; Leung, Schuckert, & Yeung, 2013). As implied in all three phases, social media serves as a crucial word-of-mouth platform that influences other travelers' decisions (Litvin, Goldsmith and Pan, 2008; Hudson, Roth, Madden & Hudson, 2015; Luo & Zhong, 2015).

Most studies on social media in tourism are consumer-centric, suggesting that travelers' use of social media or the influence of social media on tourist behavior has been studied often (Denizci Guillet, Kucukusta, & Liu, 2016). On the other hand, few researchers have focused on tourism suppliers' perspectives. Thus, little is known about how tourism suppliers or organizations utilize social media (Munar, 2012).

Research reveals that tourism organizations use social media primarily in the areas of marketing, management, communication and product distribution (Leung, Law, van Hoof, & Buhalis, 2013; Leung, Schuckert, & Yeung, 2013). First, business literature (Gelb & Sundaram, 2002; Kim & Ko, 2012) in general and tourism literature in particular (Denizci Guillet et al., 2016; Hays et al., 2013; Kim, Koh, Cha & Lee, 2015; Kim, Lim, & Brymer, 2015) argue that suppliers use social media most often for marketing purposes since traditional media is no longer sufficient and due to the popularity of social media among consumers. Indeed, a number of studies focusing on different tourism contexts (e.g. hotels, airlines, travel agencies) have found that social media is actively used as a marketing tool in the industry (e.g., Chan & Denizci Guillet, 2011; Denizci Guillet et al., 2016; Huang, 2012; Leung, Schuckert & Yeung, 2013; Phelan, Chen, & Haney, 2013). However, many organizations simply transfer their existing marketing activities onto social media platforms, rather than exploiting the transformational potential of social media. For instance, in their study of investigating social media usage of the top 133 hotel brands in China, Denizci Guillet et al. (2016) found that most of the hotels utilized social media mainly for disseminating and receiving information regarding the hotel services. In other words, few hotels used social media for more enhanced and sophisticated marketing activities, such as performing marketing research and strengthening collaboration with their affiliates

(Denizci Guillet et al., 2016; Phelan et al., 2013). A similar pattern of results was found for travel agencies (Huang, 2012), airlines (Leung, Schuckert & Yeung, 2013) and DMOs (Hays et al., 2013; Milwood, Marchiori, & Zach, 2013), indicating that tourism organizations, regardless of their type, are still in the experimental stage of utilizing social media as a marketing tool. Second, previous studies confirm that social media is used for management functions in a tourism organization, such as financial management and crisis management (e.g., Fuchs, Scholochov & Höpken, 2009; Huang, 2012; Ketter, 2016; Noone, McGuire, & Rohlf, 2011; Sigala, 2011). Specifically, Kim, Lim, and Brymer (2015) and Kim, Koh, Cha and Lee (2015) found a positive and linear effect of US restaurant firms' activities in social media on firm value. Regarding the use of social media for crisis management, Ketter (2016) argues that Facebook served as a destination image restoration tool after the Gurkha Earthquake in Nepal. Some authors also suggest that social media can be used for other management functions, such as by developing 'intra-net blogs' for training and career development in businesses (Leung, Schuckert & Yeung, 2013) or by developing 'business-to-business blogs' for internal communication among suppliers (Lew, 2007). Third, social media is used as a communication tool that facilitates interaction and engagement between suppliers and tourists (e.g. Kim, Lim, & Brymer, 2015; Kim, Koh, Cha, & Lee, 2015; Schmallegger & Carson, 2008; Thevenot, 2007). The interaction and engagement with tourists is a critical issue for suppliers since a late- or non-response to concerns raised on social media indicates that a supplier demonstrates low responsiveness to its customers, thereby contributing to a potential loss of business (Chan & Denizci Guillet, 2011). However, previous studies indicate that tourism organizations generally perform poorly in developing interaction and communication with tourists on social media (Chan & Denizci Guillet, 2011; Denizci Guillet et al., 2016; Hsu, 2012; Kim, Lim & Brymer, 2015; Phelan et al., 2013; Wattanacharoensil & Schuckert, 2015). Finally, it has been suggested that social media can be used as an indirect product distribution channel that stimulates demand and facilitates the direct distribution of products (Laws, 2001; Noone et al., 2011). A recent study surveying hoteliers in a Swiss touristic region empirically confirmed this argument by revealing that social media is actively used for selling rooms online (Inversini & Masiero, 2014). Nevertheless, evidence to support the use of social media as a tourism distribution channel is still extremely limited (Leung, Law, van Hoof, & Buhalis, 2013; Leung, Schuckert, & Yeung, 2013).

3. Methodology

The present study addresses an area of research that has been little developed and is therefore exploratory in nature. A two-phase study (pilot; primary) was conducted to develop a better understanding of social media usage of destination management organizations (DMOs). Content analysis was used to evaluate social media postings of European DMOs because it allows the researcher to 'use a set of procedures to make valid inferences from text' (Weber, 1990, p. 9).

3.1. The selection of social media platforms

As noted earlier, previous research on social media in tourism and hospitality has focused mainly on Facebook and/or Twitter (e.g. Hays et al., 2013; Hsu, 2012; Jabreel, Moreno, & Huertas, 2016; Kwok & Yu, 2013; Mariani et al., 2016; Philander & Zhong, 2016; Stankov et al., 2010) because they were considered to be the most common social media platforms that tourism organizations participated in. This is also in line with global social media account ownership and active usage data (Golbeck, 2015). For instance, Facebook, a social networking site launched in 2004, has an average of under two billion (1.79 billion for September 2016) monthly active users (Facebook, 2016), placing it as the most used social media platform in the world (Golbeck, 2015). On the other hand, Twitter—a microblogging website launched in 2006 that

enables users to post messages ('tweets') no longer than 140 characters (Jansen, Zhang, Sobel, & Chowdury, 2009), has approximately 310 million monthly active users (Twitter, 2016).

Although Facebook and Twitter account for a significant portion of available online word-of-mouth (Dijkmans, Kerkhof, & Beukeboom, 2015), other social media platforms also need to be investigated in order to contribute to the extant body of social media research. Thus, the present study includes Instagram and YouTube in the analysis because they have millions of users and focus mainly on visual rather than textual content (photos/videos)—essential for destination marketing. While Facebook is more multifaceted due to its textual and visual content, Twitter is primarily text-oriented (Hays et al., 2013). Instagram (photos) and YouTube (videos) are not only popular social media platforms for travelers but also represent ideal marketing avenues for DMOs due to their high levels of visual content.

Launched in 2010 and owned by Facebook, Instagram is a relatively new social media platform, which allows users to share photos or short videos. Instagram claims over 400 million monthly active users with an average of more than 80 million photos posted daily (Instagram, 2016). Created in 2005, YouTube is a video sharing website owned by Google. Because one can use YouTube to watch videos without having an account, it is difficult to gauge the exact number of users (Golbeck, 2015); however, the company reports over a billion users (YouTube, 2016). All four social media platforms (Facebook, Twitter, Instagram, YouTube) were selected for analysis in this study.

3.2. Pilot study

To determine the appropriate measures for the content analysis, a pilot study was undertaken in December 2015. Since Hays et al. (2013) examined only Facebook pages and Twitter accounts of DMOs, the aim of the pilot study was to examine the applicability of those measures (developed by Hays et al. (2013)) for Instagram and YouTube and to identify any additional measures that could be used. A sample of seven European countries (France, Germany, Italy, Spain, Turkey, Russia, and United Kingdom) was selected using purposive sampling and for the following reasons: (1) each is among the top 10 tourist destinations in terms of international arrivals and/or receipts, (2) each has a well-established DMO responsible for destination marketing, and (3) each has been using at least one of the most popular social media platforms for a minimum of three years. The DMOs included were the France Tourism Development Agency, the German National Tourist Board, the Italian National Tourist Board, the Russian Federal Agency for Tourism, Tour Spain (TURESPAÑA), the Turkish Ministry of Culture and Tourism, and Visit Britain. All postings on Facebook, Twitter, Instagram and YouTube between September 1 and November 30, 2015 were analyzed. On the basis of the pilot study, measures developed by Hays et al. (2013) for Facebook and Twitter were successfully adapted for Instagram and YouTube. Thus, the consistency of measures across all platforms was ensured in order to make valid comparisons. Furthermore, the pilot study revealed that YouTube enables users a specific function (i.e. disliking a post) unlike the other three platforms. In accordance with this function, two measures (number of posts that are disliked and number of dislikes for a post) were added to the content analysis. An additional measure (i.e. major theme of post) was also developed by the authors with the argument that DMOs use social media in order to develop a favorable destination image. Finally, the pilot study determined all relevant measures that would be used in the primary study (see Table A1 for the full list).

3.3. Population and data collection

DMOs of European countries comprise the target population of this study. The rationale behind selecting European destinations is simply that they account for 51% of all international tourist arrivals (608 million arrivals in 2015) and 41% of tourism receipts (US\$451 billion in

2015) (WTO, 2016). In addition to being the world's most visited region, Europe includes many of the world's largest and most mature destinations that have well-established national level DMOs. No sampling method was used in the selection of countries. It was decided that data would be collected from the population rather than a sample: 50 countries classified by European Union (EU) as member states, candidate countries, potential candidates, and other European countries (see Table B1 for full list).

Data collection began with an initial scan of destinations' official web sites to obtain links to their DMOs' official social media accounts in order to screen out unofficial accounts administered by other entities. Keywords were used in combination with country name to locate official DMO web sites (e.g. national tourist/tourism board/office, official tourist/tourism board/office, official travel and tourism web site). After confirming that web sites were official, links of social media accounts were obtained. To confirm the authenticity of social media accounts they were cross-checked with links on DMOs' official home pages used to direct visitors to social media platforms. Additionally, some DMOs have multiple accounts in each social media platform that promote different regions of a country (e.g. France, Germany, Netherlands, Spain, UK), which were excluded from the analysis. Only the official national level social media accounts operated by national level DMOs were included.

Language was used to screen social media accounts and only those operating in English were included in the analysis. While a great majority of DMOs have English-language accounts, language selection of social media accounts presented a few minor problems. Some DMOs (e.g. San Marino, Monaco, Luxembourg) had bilingual accounts (i.e. English and their official national language). For these DMOs, only the English-language posts were included in the analysis. The exceptions to the English-language rule were Liechtenstein, Russia and Spain. The Russian Federal Agency for Tourism posts only in Russian on all social media platforms except Instagram (since it does not have an official presence on Instagram). Likewise, 'Liechtenstein Marketing' (Liechtenstein's official DMO) posts mostly in German on all four platforms. Since the authors speak Russian and German, it was decided that postings of both Liechtenstein and Russia would be included. Tour Spain, on the other hand, posts on Facebook in the target market's official language (posts in English on the remaining three social media platforms). In other words, the Facebook page of Tour Spain determines the language of users based on the Internet protocol (IP) address (using geolocation) from which they connect. Therefore, Facebook posts of Tour Spain were analyzed in the researchers' native language.

A systematic random sampling method was used to select posts for analysis. Since extracting the population of posts on each social media platform for each DMO is extremely difficult and the total number of posts varies greatly, a systematic random sample was created for 2015. Examining the social media usage of DMOs for a total of 30 days (1 month) is considered adequate when the total number of destinations and social media accounts were taken into account (assuming a total of 200 accounts based on 50 destinations on four platforms). First, a sampling interval of 12 was calculated (365 divided by 30). Then, a number (i.e. seven) was randomly selected from the sampling interval. Finally, a systematic random sample of every 12th date starting from January 7 and ending December 21, 2015 was selected. In the event of several posts on a given date, two were selected (the first and last posts of the day). If there was no post for a selected date, the next interval day was selected.

Two researchers collected the data separately to minimize the possibility of personal bias. Only for the postings of the DMOs of Liechtenstein and Russia, two additional independent researchers (fluent in German and Russian) were recruited. Minor discrepancies between the researchers were clarified through an iterative process of constructive discussion. Due to the dynamic nature of social media and continual updates of DMOs on their accounts, some statistics changed rapidly during data collection. To address this, data were collected in

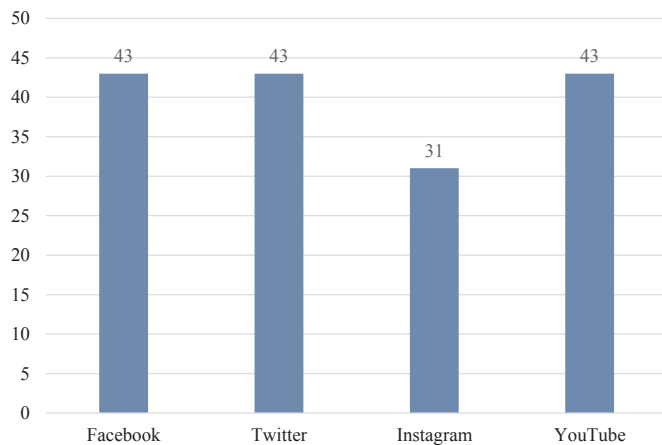


Fig. 1. Number of European DMOs on social media (as of 12/31/2015).

the months of March and April 2016 using a retrospective approach. Following the above-mentioned procedures, a total of 3546 social media postings (755 Facebook, 1521 Twitter, 1001 Instagram, and 269 YouTube) were obtained. It is important to note that several spreadsheets containing formulas and functions were developed specifically for this study using Microsoft Excel. These spreadsheets were utilized both in collecting and analyzing data. Additionally, SPSS 22.0 was used for correlation analysis and inter-rater reliability.

4. Results and discussion

In order to make a comparative analysis, results were visualized and discussed based on the four social media platforms.

4.1. Basic social media statistics for European DMOs

DMOs with an official presence on social media platforms are illustrated in Fig. 1. Results indicate that the majority of DMOs in Europe are officially represented on social media. Forty-three DMOs have official accounts on Facebook, Twitter and YouTube and 31 participate in Instagram – which appears to be the least common social media platform. Of the 50 destinations analyzed, five (Armenia, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Kosovo, Ukraine and Vatican City) did not have an official presence on any of the four social media platforms.

Additionally, the dates on which DMOs established their social media accounts range from 2005 (Austria's YouTube account) to 2015 (Slovakia's Instagram account). Germany emerged as the earliest adopter of both Facebook and Twitter, having established its Facebook page and Twitter account in 2008. It is worth mentioning that Instagram does not explicitly provide the membership date for accounts; therefore, membership dates for Instagram accounts were generated by using the date of the first post. Based on this, Denmark emerged as the first to

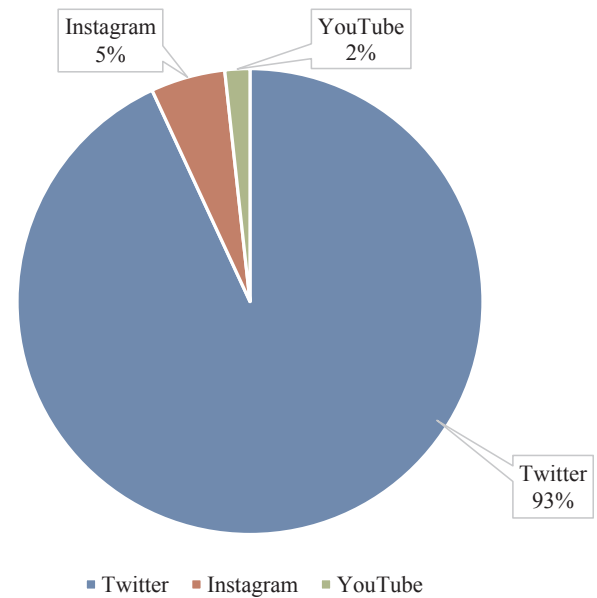


Fig. 2. Distribution of total posts of the combined DMOs by social media platform (from start of membership to 12/31/2015).

join Instagram (2012). Table 1 presents the early adopters of each social media platform.

The total number of posts for an account was easily tracked on Twitter, Instagram and YouTube, but not Facebook. Thus, this study is unable to report an accurate number of total DMO posts for Facebook. For this reason, Fig. 2 demonstrates the distribution of total posts of the combined DMOs by each social media platform except for Facebook. As Fig. 2 illustrates, Twitter was by far the most commonly used social media platform by DMOs, regardless of a number of factors that could skew this distribution (e.g. creation date of each social media platform, dates on which DMOs established their accounts, number of DMOs on each platform). Tweets accounted for 93% of total posts of the combined DMOs, clearly indicating that DMOs contributed more often to Twitter. A similar pattern of results for a sample of seven top European destinations was also found in the pilot study, where Facebook posts were individually counted and added into the analysis, revealing Twitter (73%) to be more commonly used than Facebook (10%), Instagram (15%), and YouTube (2%). It is also important to note that Portugal (71,538 tweets, 18.8%), United Kingdom (36,504 tweets, 9.6%) and Georgia (25,459 tweets, 6.7%) were the first three destinations – all having created their accounts in 2009 – that tweeted the most. These three destinations account for more than one-third of all tweets, clearly skewing the total number of tweets for all DMOs. Furthermore, Croatia (3239 posts, 16.5%) posted most often on Instagram, followed by Denmark (1693 posts, 8.6%) and Norway (1177 posts, 6%); however, these three destinations attracted less than

Table 1
Early adopters of social media among European DMOs.

Facebook		Twitter		Instagram		YouTube	
Germany	June 2008	Germany	14 Nov. 2008	Denmark	13 Jan. 2012	Austria	27 Oct. 2005
Georgia	Nov. 2008	Spain	19 Dec. 2008	Norway	17 Feb. 2012	Sweden	9 Nov. 2005
Sweden ^a	Dec. 2008	Georgia	15 Jan. 2009	Portugal	24 Sep. 2012	Montenegro	18 Nov. 2005
Cyprus ^a	Dec. 2008	UK	19 Jan. 2009	Georgia	18 Oct. 2012	Croatia	22 Nov. 2005
Liechtenstein ^a	Dec. 2008	Netherlands	29 Jan. 2009	Slovenia	7 Nov. 2012	Spain	7 Dec. 2005

^a Because Facebook provides the membership date in “month-year” format, those destinations were ranked based on the first posting's date.

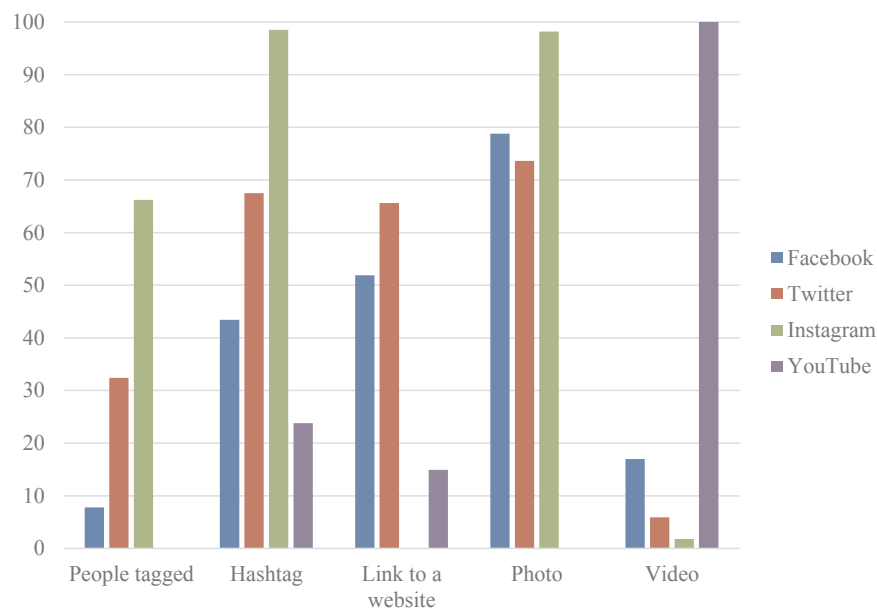


Fig. 3. Distribution of content material included in social media postings of the combined DMOs during 2015.

100,000 followers. On the other hand, Switzerland (685 posts, 10.4%), Bulgaria (592 posts, 9%) and Russia (418 posts, 6.3%) were the first three destinations that uploaded the greatest number of videos on *YouTube*; however, Russia's videos reached fewer than 500,000 views.

It has been suggested that DMOs reach a much larger audience via social media than with traditional communication media (Hays et al., 2013). Accordingly, the audience size for each social media platform should be carefully examined. When measuring the audience size, the following measures were used: total number of likes on *Facebook* pages (*Facebook* pages are followed through 'likes'), followers on *Twitter* and *Instagram*, and subscribers to and views on *YouTube*. Two different measures were used for *YouTube* since users watch videos with or without having an account. Subscribers represent the number of followers that have an account, whereas views indicate the total number of views for all posts on a *YouTube* channel (account) by those with or without having an account. Therefore, one should keep in mind that total views do not directly correspond to the number of followers on *YouTube* since it takes a single user's each view into account as a different user – nevertheless, it gives an idea about the number of followers on *YouTube*. Audience sizes of the combined DMOs were as follows: 22.4 million for *Facebook*, 2.3 million for *Twitter*, 1.3 million for *Instagram*, and approximately 140,000 for *YouTube* (in terms of subscribers). Given the fact that *YouTube* channels of European DMOs reached over 228 million views, it is expected that the exact audience size for *YouTube* is much larger than 140,000 people. For the audience size, it is important to note that Turkey ranked first on all four platforms (over 4.4 million *Facebook* likes, nearly 800,000 *Twitter* followers, over 250,000 *Instagram* followers, over 15,000 *YouTube* subscribers and 68 million *YouTube* views). It might be argued that the audience size might be affected by the membership period of a DMO on a particular social media platform. For this reason, a series of correlation analyses were performed. No statistically significant correlations were found between the membership periods (calculated in terms of months for each DMO by each platform) and the following measures: the total number of *Facebook* likes ($p=0.965$), *Twitter* followers ($p=0.179$) and *Instagram* followers ($p=0.452$), and *YouTube* subscribers ($p=0.163$) and views ($p=0.336$).

4.2. Categorizing the social media measures

As mentioned above, 3546 social media postings (755 *Facebook*

posts, 1521 *tweets*, 1001 *Instagram* posts, and 269 *YouTube* videos) were collected and analyzed using 37 measures (Table A1, Part C). Due to the large number of measures used, it was determined to perform a data reduction process in order to identify the underlying categories of relevant measures. To do this, a content analysis was performed because 'many words of text can be classified into much fewer content categories' (Weber, 1990, p. 7). Therefore, the 37 measures used in examining social media usage of DMOs were systematically categorized using two independent raters with expertise in social media research. The two independent raters were recruited to minimize the risk of researcher bias (Hall & Valentin, 2005; Stepchenkova, 2012) and were asked to classify the measures into meaningful categories. A consistent categorization process along with a set of rules was developed and raters were trained accordingly, after which they independently evaluated and categorized the measures. In case of disagreements, raters discussed the specific category until consensus was reached. Finally, seven categories emerged from the content analysis process: (1) *content*, (2) *major theme*, (3) *information type*, (4) *engagement*, (5) *interactivity*, (6) *promotion*, and (7) *customer service*.

To evaluate the level of consistency between the raters' categorization process, Cohen's kappa, a statistical coefficient of inter-rater reliability for qualitative (categorical) items, was estimated (Landis & Koch, 1977; Neuendorf, 2002). Cohen's kappa has a range from 0 to 1, with larger values indicating higher reliability. In this study, Cohen's kappa was found to be 0.894, indicating almost perfect inter-rater agreement (Landis & Koch, 1977).

4.3. Content analysis of the posts

The results reported here were derived from the data (a total of 3546 social media postings of European DMOs) that were content analyzed during the study period (1/1/2015–12/31/2015).

4.3.1. Content

The first category (*content*) consisted of different types of content material used in DMO posts to reinforce message range and richness, such as whether or not people are tagged, hashtags are used, and photos, videos or links to websites are provided. Fig. 3 depicts the type of content that DMOs included in their posts. Interestingly, no people were tagged by DMOs in any of the 269 videos analyzed on *YouTube*. Average number of people tagged was less than one for the remaining

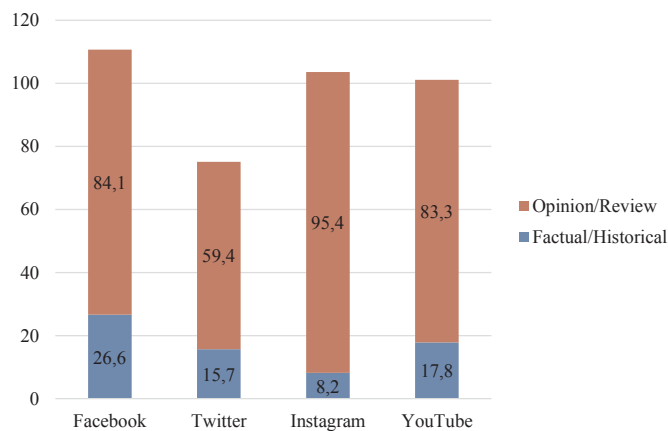


Fig. 4. Distribution of information type used in social media postings of the combined DMOs during 2015.

three platforms (*Facebook* 0.4, *Twitter* 0.5, *Instagram* 0.7 people), indicating that DMOs tend to fail to attract specific users (travelers) in their posts.

As shown in Fig. 3, mentions (tagging people in the post) and hashtags were most commonly used on *Instagram*. 'Hashtag' is a keyword preceded by a hash mark (#) that makes the post searchable in the social media platform. Almost all posts (986 posts, 98.5%) on *Instagram* contained a hashtag. Hashtags were least used on *YouTube* (64 posts, 23.8%) because they are confined to the comments section alone. In other words, unless a DMO leaves a comment with hashtags on its own *YouTube* post, the hashtag does not achieve what it intends to. The most frequently used hashtags were also investigated for each DMO, revealing that destination names are used most often as hashtags, either alone (e.g. Denmark, Liechtenstein, Malta, Poland, Portugal, Romania) or in brief phrases (e.g. Visit Austria, I Like Italy, Visit Luxembourg, Visit Spain, Visit Sweden). Furthermore, it was found that the same hashtags were usually used across all platforms.

While *Instagram* posts included the highest rate of photos (98.2%), *YouTube* included the most videos (269 posts); however, this was as expected since *YouTube* is a video-sharing platform and *Instagram* is a photo-sharing platform although short videos can also be posted. Therefore, for an unbiased analysis, *Instagram* should be ignored while interpreting the usage of photos in order to enhance the message, whereas *YouTube* should be ignored in the interpretation of the usage of videos. After excluding *Instagram* for photos and *YouTube* for videos, results revealed that both photos (595 posts, 78.8%) and videos (128 posts, 17%) were used the most on *Facebook* as content material to enrich posts. Of the 3546 posts analyzed on all four platforms during 2015, only 14.2% (505 posts) contained a video (*Facebook* 128, *Twitter* 90, *Instagram* 18, *YouTube* 269). As additional content material, a website link was included most often on *Twitter* (998 tweets, 65.6%), followed by *Facebook* (392 posts, 51.9%) and *YouTube* (40 videos, 14.9%). Based on its terms of use, posting links to websites (web URLs) is not enabled on *Instagram* for the purpose of avoiding spam. Even if a post contains a link to a website, it is not clickable. Therefore, links to websites on *Instagram* were not analyzed as content material.

4.3.2. Major theme

The second category (*major theme*) included only one measure, namely the major theme projected by a social media posting. Previous research on social media that examined DMO-generated content themes is quite limited (Stepchenkova & Zhan, 2013); however, each post on a social media platform contains a specific theme. More specifically, the present study argues that DMOs use social media not only to inform visitors but also particularly to develop destination image. The *major theme* was not included in the category of *content* by the two

independent raters because it focuses on the entire message of a given post, rather than just content material that enriches the message.

To investigate the major theme, each post was classified using a total of 15 cognitive image attributes (categories) (e.g. natural attractions, historical attractions, local cuisine, recreation facilities, friendliness of people, personal safety) derived from previous destination image studies (e.g. Baloglu & McCleary, 1999; Baloglu & Mangalolu, 2001; Sönmez & Sirakaya, 2002; Beerli & Martín, 2004; Stepchenkova & Zhan, 2013). Because some posts did not fit any particular image attributes (e.g. a "good morning" tweet), a final category named 'general' was added. All textual and visual content (only photos) in a post was evaluated using a holistic approach for its major theme. Videos were not analyzed since they simultaneously include multiple image attributes. Accordingly, a total of 3041 posts that did not include videos were analyzed (627 *Facebook*, 1431 *Twitter*, 983 *Instagram* posts). In order to assess the level of consistency between the two coders (researchers who independently collected and coded the data) regarding the major theme of a post, the Cohen's kappa coefficient of inter-coder reliability was estimated. The inter-coder reliabilities were 0.870 for *Facebook* posts, 0.882 for *Twitter* posts, and 0.890 for *Instagram* posts, which indicated almost perfect agreement between the coders.

The results indicate that the most frequent major theme projected by DMOs in their social media postings was 'natural attractions' (48%) across all platforms. Other frequent major themes included cultural attractions (12.5%), historical attractions (8.5%), local cuisine (6.4%), and recreation facilities (5.2%). These major themes account for over 80% of all posts.

4.3.3. Information type

The third category (*information type*) is related to the classification of information in the social media postings. Following Hays et al. (2013), posts are classified in two ways based on the type of information provided: (1) factual or historical information and (2) opinion or review. For instance, dates and location of an event or the history of a festival refers to the factual or historical information. On the other hand, posts that are categorized as opinion or review usually included more subjective information, such as top 10 restaurants in the destination or review of a hotel. The distribution of type of information included in the posts of the combined DMOs is presented in Fig. 4.

Across all platforms, the information provided is mainly opinion or review, ranging from 59.4% (*Twitter*) to 95.4% (*Instagram*). Total percentage exceeds 100 on *Facebook*, *Instagram* and *YouTube* because some posts include both factual/historical information and opinion/review. Similarly, total percentage falls below 100 on *Twitter* because some tweets include neither factual/historical information nor opinion/review (e.g. tweets that are only greetings or request feedback from travelers). With more than one-fourth of its posts, the *Facebook* accounts of DMOs ranked first in terms of providing factual/historical information, followed by *YouTube* (17.8%), *Twitter* (15.7%) and *Instagram* (8.2%). For the combined information type across all platforms, while the top-five DMOs providing mainly opinion or review (with more than 90%) represented Europe's well-established destinations (i.e. Turkey, Germany, UK, France and Spain respectively), those providing factual information (with more than 40%) were the emerging destinations (i.e. Moldova, Azerbaijan, Monaco, Latvia and Romania respectively).

4.3.4. Engagement

Another important category of the content analysis focused on the user's (traveler) *engagement* with social media accounts of DMOs. van Doorn et al. (2010, p. 254) defines customer engagement as 'behaviors that go beyond simple transactions, and may be specifically defined as a customer's behavioral manifestations that have a brand or firm focus, beyond purchase, resulting from motivational drivers'. These behavioral manifestations, other than purchases, can be negative (e.g. negative comment about destination on a social media platform) or positive (e.g.

Table 2

Average number of engagement metrics per post for the combined DMOs in 2015.

	Facebook	Twitter	Instagram	YouTube
Likes/Favorites	952.4	24	1530.4	35.2
Shares/Re-tweets ^a	203	16.2	–	–
Comments/Replies	26.5	1.1	26.7	2.2
Dislikes ^b	–	–	–	2.5

^a Number of shares is not available on both *Instagram* and *YouTube*.^b “Dislike” function is available only on *YouTube*.

sharing DMO post and recommending destination to others). In this study, to assess engagement, a number of metrics were computed (i.e. average number of likes/favorites, shares/retweets, comments/replies and dislikes) for the relevant social media platforms. Table 2 shows these engagement metrics for the combined DMOs. It is also important to note that all results reported here represent only positive engagement.

Liking, sharing, and commenting are the three common types of customer engagement on social media platforms (Kabadayi & Price, 2014; Oviedo-García, Muñoz-Expósito, Castellanos-Verdugo, & Sancho-Mejías, 2014). As given in Table 2, *Instagram* (average number of likes = 1530.4) and *Facebook* (952.4) posts of DMOs create much higher levels of engagement in terms of likes than *YouTube* (35.2) and *Twitter* (24) posts across all DMOs. However, 'liking' a post is the simplest form of engagement on social media. A second type of engagement involves getting the users to share the posts of DMOs. Since 'sharing' leads to more effective dissemination of the post to other users (Moore & McElroy, 2012; Ruiz-Mafe, Martí-Parreño, & Sanz-Blas, 2014), it is considered more effective than liking for customer engagement. Even though sharing is enabled on *Instagram* and *YouTube*, the number of shares is not available. For this reason, the sharing metrics were computed only for *Facebook* and *Twitter* posts of DMOs. While a *Facebook* post by a European DMO was shared by an average number of 203 users, a tweet by a European DMO was retweeted by only an average number of 16.2 users. Furthermore, Mariani et al. (2016) argue that 'commenting' is the most effective type of engagement on social media since it takes more time to write a comment when compared with liking and sharing a post. The results indicate that *Instagram* (average number of comments = 26.7) and *Facebook* (26.5) provide the highest level of customer engagement for DMOs. On the other hand, a *YouTube* video or a DMO *tweet* creates an average number of less than three comments. Finally, 'dislike' – as a form of customer engagement – is available only on *YouTube*. The videos on *YouTube* resulted in a combined average number of less than three dislikes across all DMOs.

Because commenting is considered the most effective type of user engagement, Table 3 displays the leading European DMOs in terms of average number of comments per post in 2015. Turkey emerged as the only destination that listed among the top five destinations for user engagement across all social media platforms (with an average number of 199.1 *Facebook*, 7.3 *Twitter*, 59.8 *Instagram* and 13.3 *YouTube* comments per post). Additionally, for the combined average number

Table 3

Top five DMOs for customer engagement (in terms of average number of comments) during 2015.

Facebook	Twitter	Instagram	YouTube	Combined
Netherlands	Turkey	Ireland	Turkey	Turkey
Turkey	UK	Spain	Albania	Finland
Switzerland	Ireland	Finland	Germany	Ireland
Finland	Croatia	Turkey	Sweden	Netherlands
Italy	Spain	UK	Greece	Spain

Table 4

The degree of interactivity of posts for the combined DMOs during 2015.

	Facebook	Twitter	Instagram	YouTube	Combined
Non-interactive posts	476	861	651	234	2222
Interactive posts	279	660	350	35	1324
Total posts	755	1521	1001	269	3546
Interactivity (%)	37.0%	43.4%	35.0%	13.0%	37.3%

of comments across all platforms, the top five DMOs were Turkey, Finland, Ireland, Netherlands and Spain (with an average of 49.9, 47.6, 45.0, 41.0, 26.6 comments, respectively). Furthermore, correlation analysis was performed to investigate the relationship between engagement levels of DMOs on social media (in terms of combined average number of comments on all four platforms) and international tourist arrivals (for the year 2015) of destinations. Results revealed a positive ($r=0.321$) and moderate ($p=0.40$) relationship between user engagement and international tourist arrivals (Cohen, 1977).

4.3.5. Interactivity

The fifth category (*interactivity*) focused on the extent to which European DMOs use the four social media platforms to interact with their users (travelers). In this study, 'interactivity' refers to a post that directly poses a question to travelers or requests input from travelers, such as feedback, photos or videos (Hays et al., 2013). For instance, a post by Georgia's DMO (*#Georgia is home to several awe-inspiring waterfalls. What Georgia waterfall do you love to visit?*) was considered interactive. Table 4 summarizes the degree of interactivity for the combined DMOs on each social media platform. Over the course of 2015, the degree of interactivity of the posts ranged from 13.0% (*YouTube*) to 43.4% (*Twitter*), making *Twitter* the most interactive social media platform for European DMOs. Additionally, a positive ($r=0.327$) and moderate (Cohen, 1977) correlation was found between the combined interactivity levels of DMOs on all four social media platforms and international tourist arrivals of destinations ($p=0.37$), indicating that as interactivity on social media increases, tourist arrivals increase as well.

Of the 3546 posts analyzed on all four platforms, only 37.3% (1324 posts) were classified as interactive, indicating that the majority of posts (62.7%, 2222 posts) across all platforms was not interactive in nature. However, some DMOs contributed much more interactive content than others. Table 5 describes the top five DMOs with the highest degree of interactivity on each social media platform. With more than 70% interactivity, Andorra on *Facebook*, Norway on *Twitter*, Netherlands on *Instagram* and Russia on *YouTube* ranked first. The leading DMOs in terms of interactivity were considerably different across all platforms, resulting in a diverse range of destinations. Furthermore, for the combined degree of interactivity across all platforms, France (65.8%) ranked first, followed by Cyprus (62.5%), Russia (54.5%), Luxembourg (54.0%), and Norway (50.5%).

Table 5

Interactivity of top five DMOs on each social media platform during 2015.

Facebook		Twitter		Instagram		YouTube		Combined	
Andorra	73.9%	Norway	76.1%	Netherlands	72.3%	Russia	75.0%	France	65.8%
Cyprus	68.2%	France	69.6%	France	69.6%	Portugal	66.7%	Cyprus	62.5%
Croatia	65.2%	Greece	62.5%	Cyprus	63.4%	Turkey	56.5%	Russia	54.5%
Germany	61.1%	Austria	62.2%	Finland	60.0%	Sweden	50.0%	Luxembourg	54.0%
Czech Republic	60.0%	Luxembourg	61.5%	Iceland	47.1%	UK	23.8%	Norway	50.5%

4.3.6. Promotion

The sixth category (*promotion*) deals with the type of promotional information utilized by European DMOs on social media. Previous research argued that DMOs typically utilize social media to promote their destinations (Hays et al., 2013; Mariani et al., 2016). Indeed, 89% of all posts on the four social media platforms were classified as promotion-related (Facebook 89.9%, Twitter 85.5%, Instagram 90.6%, YouTube 100%). Fig. 5 shows the type and distribution of promotional information used by European DMOs during 2015. These promotional information categories were not mutually exclusive, indicating that several things were usually promoted in a single post. As indicated in Fig. 5, it is certain that DMOs most often promote 'a specific destination' within their countries (76.6% of all promotion-related posts). Using the combined percentage of all promotion-related posts, results revealed that attractions or hotels (33.7%), events (23.4), and restaurants or foods specific to destinations (21.6%) were the other most-promoted areas on the four social media platforms, respectively. The official websites of the DMOs (21.0%), external websites (8.8%, usually the websites of tourism establishments in the destination) and other social media outlets of DMOs (5.2%) were also promoted.

4.3.7. Customer service

The final category (*customer service*) focused on issues related to customer service in order to understand whether or not DMOs use social media to provide customer service. For this purpose, social media postings of the DMOs responding to criticisms, enquiries, and compliments were analyzed (Fig. 6). It is apparent that DMOs do not often use social media as a customer service tool. This is reflected by only 9.5% of all posts classified as customer service-related across all platforms. As summarized in Fig. 6, a great majority of all customer service related

posts (284 out of 337 customer service related posts) were only responding to praises (i.e. thanking customers). Of the 3546 posts analyzed in this study, 41 posts were solely published in order to respond to customer enquiries. Likewise, only 12 posts were published specifically to respond to criticisms. These results indicate that European DMOs use social media to a great extent to respond to positive customer service issues. Posts that directly respond to the negative ones, on the other hand, were extremely low. Furthermore, none of the world's top 10 destinations (in terms of international arrivals and/or receipts, e.g. France, Germany, Italy, Spain, Turkey, Russia and UK) were listed among the top five DMOs providing customer service on social media. Instead, for the combined customer service-related posts across all platforms, Portugal ranked first, followed by Estonia, Slovenia, Norway and Switzerland (with over 20 posts). Finally, DMOs used Twitter the most for issues related to customer service (221 posts), followed by Facebook, Instagram and YouTube accounts (with 49, 36, 31 posts, respectively).

5. Conclusions

The present study explores how European DMOs use social media to promote and market their destinations. The results make important theoretical and practical contributions to the understanding of social media usage within the context of DMOs.

5.1. Theoretical and practical contributions

Five years after the initial study by Stankov et al. (2010), which found that only less than half of the 39 DMOs in Europe were officially represented on Facebook, results of this study confirm that social media

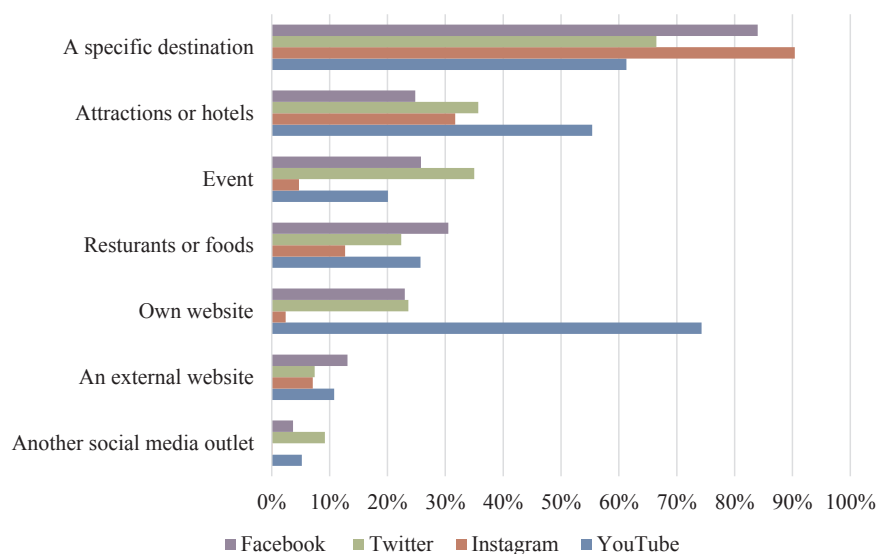


Fig. 5. Distribution of promotional information for the combined DMOs during 2015.

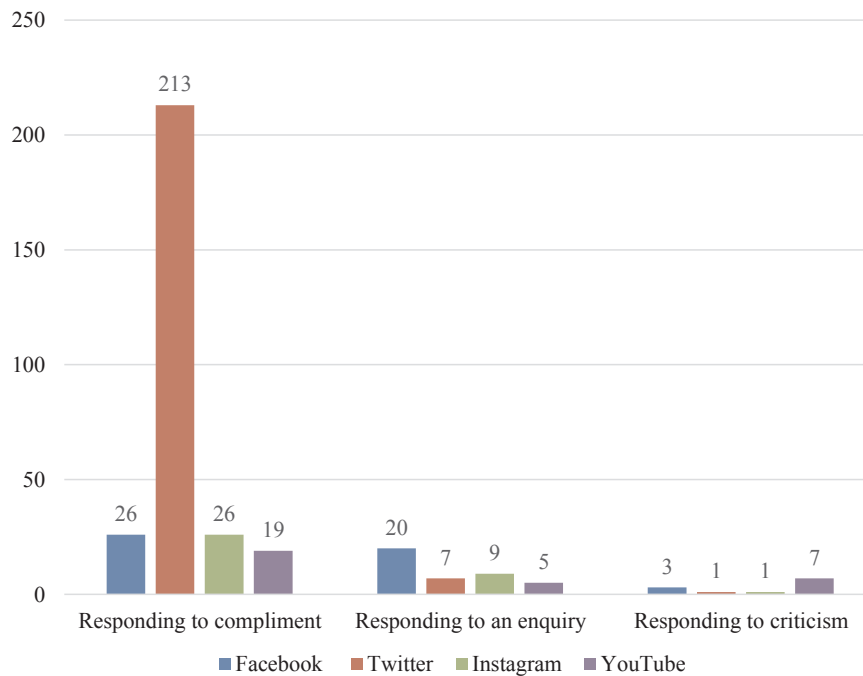


Fig. 6. Type and number of customer service related posts for the combined DMOs during 2015.

is now of interest to European DMOs. More specifically, the majority of the 50 European destinations analyzed in this study have an official presence on *Facebook*, *Twitter*, *Instagram* and *YouTube*. Although the dates on which DMOs have created their social media accounts vary, Austria became the first European destination to join social media in 2005 by creating its *YouTube* account among all four platforms. Other early adopters of social media are Georgia, Germany, Sweden and Spain (creating at least two of their accounts earlier than others). It is interesting that some of the world's top 10 tourism destinations (e.g. France, Italy, Turkey and Russia) joined social media much later. Nevertheless, the membership period does not directly correspond with some statistics, which are used to measure success in social media, such as 'audience size' (e.g. total number of likes on *Facebook*, *Twitter* and *Instagram* followers, *YouTube* subscribers and total views). For all four platforms, no statistically significant correlations were found between membership periods and audience size measures. In other words, the length of time on social media does not predict success or activity. Accounts operating for a longer period of time might have fewer followers or likes than those operating for a shorter period of time or vice versa (Hays et al., 2013; Zouganeli, Trihas, & Antonaki, 2011). Across all platforms, Turkey is the most obvious example of this: it ranks first in total number of likes, followers, subscribers and views. When total number of posts is considered, *Twitter* was found to be the most commonly used social media platform whereas *YouTube* was the least commonly used. *Twitter*'s popularity is explained by the fact that its users generally update their status more frequently than other social media platforms (Hays et al., 2013; Java, Song, Finin, & Tseng, 2007). Additionally, despite its popularity as a social media platform, the less frequent use of *YouTube* by European DMOs might be explained by the fact that more time and other resources are required for producing promotional videos, hence the lower level of its use over other platforms.

From a theoretical standpoint, seven categories emerged from the content analysis of measures used to examine European DMOs' social media usage: (1) *content*, (2) *major theme*, (3) *information type*, (4) *engagement*, (5) *interactivity*, (6) *promotion* and (7) *customer service*. This categorization of measures is the major theoretical as well as methodological contribution of this study. Specifically, a large number of

diverse measures (without incorporating them into meaningful measurement categories) were used in previous research on social media usage in tourism (e.g. Hays et al., 2013; Kwok & Yu, 2013; Lei, Pratt, & Wang, 2016; Mariani et al., 2016; Roque & Raposo, 2016; Wattanacharoensil & Schuckert, 2015; Yang & Wang, 2015). However, social media measurement is quite immature (Murdough, 2009) since big data has been mainly used in social media research (Mahrt & Scharkow, 2013; Xiang, Du, Ma, & Fan, 2017). Therefore, it seems that the use of diverse measures further complicates the interpretation of big data and the findings revealed. Thus, the present study develops a seven-category measurement model (*content*, *major theme*, *information type*, *engagement*, *interactivity*, *promotion*, and *customer service*) for social media research in tourism. Furthermore, while there are many social media platforms, most existing studies on social media in tourism are confined to a single platform – either *Twitter* (Jabreel et al., 2016; Philander & Zhong, 2016; Sevin, 2013) or *Facebook* (e.g. Hsu, 2012; Mariani et al., 2016; Wattanacharoensil & Schuckert, 2015; Yoo & Lee, 2015). It is important to note that an extremely limited number of studies focused on both *Facebook* and *Twitter* (e.g. Hays et al., 2013; Leung, Bai, & Stahura, 2015). However, Tufekci (2014) argues that single-platform studies create important methodological challenges due to the sociocultural complexity of user behavior and different features of each platform. By analyzing four social media platforms, the present study not only contributes to the broader understanding of social media usage but also minimizes the methodological challenges associated with single-platform studies by making measures compatible across all platforms. Another contribution of this study to the literature is the moderate positive correlations revealed among engagement, interactivity and international tourist arrivals. More specifically, the higher the engagement or the higher the interactivity on social media, the higher the number of international tourists.

From a practical standpoint, the present study provides a big picture of social media usage of European DMOs by content analyzing social media postings over a full year on four popular social media platforms. For instance, in terms of *content*, the results indicate that DMOs share videos less frequently than photos and mentions are used less than hashtags. The study also revealed that DMOs generally use hashtags that are familiar in their traditional advertising campaigns (e.g. Explore

Georgia, I Feel Slovenia, I Like Italy, Love Great Britain, Visit Spain, Visit Sweden) rather than hashtags that represent the unfamiliar or unique destination characteristics. Based on the argument that DMOs use social media to develop their destination image, the present study classified the *major theme* (i.e. projected destination image) of each social media posting using a set of cognitive image attributes. Across all platforms, the most-frequently projected major theme by European DMOs was 'natural attractions' (consistent with [Stepchenkova and Zhan \(2013\)](#)), followed by "cultural attractions, historical attractions, local cuisine, and recreation facilities." Regarding *information type*, a similar pattern of results was found in this study as in that carried out by [Hays et al. \(2013\)](#), indicating that information provided by DMOs in their posts is mainly subjective (i.e. opinions/reviews) rather objective (i.e. factual/historical information). The results indicate that well-established and highly mature destinations provide mainly subjective information, whereas emerging destinations are more likely to provide factual information. Additionally, results show that *Instagram* and *Facebook* posts of DMOs create much higher levels of customer engagement than *Twitter* and *YouTube* posts. Although several metrics (e.g. liking/sharing) are available to examine social media engagement, commenting is considered most effective, because users invest more time by writing comments rather than simply liking or sharing a post ([Mariani et al., 2016](#)). Using the combined average number of comments on all four platforms, Turkey was found to have the highest level of engagement among all European destinations. Finland, Ireland, Netherlands, and Spain were the other European destinations with higher levels of social media engagement. Furthermore, the results in this study differ from those in [Hays et al. \(2013\)](#) and [Roque and Raposo \(2016\)](#) regarding the *interactivity* of social media platforms. In both studies, authors argue that DMOs utilize *Facebook* much more interactively than *Twitter*. Conversely, the present study confirms that DMOs use *Twitter* much more interactively than *Instagram*, *Facebook* and *YouTube*, respectively. This might be explained by the nature of *Twitter*—because it is primarily about 'what's happening now' ([Kwak, Lee, Park, & Moon, 2010](#); [Mathioudakis & Koudas, 2010](#)), this makes *Twitter* a more appropriate platform for DMOs to ask travelers questions or request feedbacks, photos or videos. Contrary to the top DMOs (Turkey, Finland, Ireland, Netherlands and Spain) with the highest level of engagement, the clear-cut leaders in terms of interactivity are France, Cyprus, Russia, Luxembourg, and Norway, respectively. Additionally, as pointed out by [Munar \(2012\)](#), the study revealed a great majority of all posts are *promotion*-related and specific destinations (i.e. cities) within the country are by far the most-often promoted across all platforms, indicating that European DMOs may be conducting regional promotional campaigns rather than promoting the entire country. Attractions, hotels, events, and restaurants or local cuisine were the other most-promoted dimensions on social media. Last but not least,

this study focused on whether or not DMOs provide *customer service* through social media. Similar to the findings of [Hays et al. \(2013\)](#), the posts classified as customer service-related were extremely low, suggesting that either DMOs do not use social media as a customer service tool or travelers do not use social media to voice their satisfaction or complaints. In today's digital world, where social media has emerged as an important channel for customer service, the probability of the latter is low. Indeed, the 2012 social media report by Nielsen, a global research company headquartered in New York, indicates that nearly half of US consumers use social media to complain, to report their satisfaction, or for inquiries ([Nielsen, 2012](#)). By taking into account posts classified in this study as promotion-related (nearly 90%) and customer service-related (less than 10%), the present study confirms that European DMOs still utilize social media as a traditional marketing tool, rather than exploiting it as a customer service tool in order to mitigate customer problems. Interestingly, well-established and highly mature destinations demonstrate poor performance in using social media as a customer service tool compared with Europe's emerging destinations.

5.2. Limitations and future research

Limitations of the present study should be recognized when interpreting the results and used as opportunities for future research directions. First, the findings of this study are specific to only one continent. Therefore, future research replicating this study with DMOs from other geographical regions of the world (e.g. Americas, Africa, Asia and the Pacific) will increase our understanding of this important research area. Given the fact that most DMOs included in this study are from highly mature destinations, it would be interesting to conduct a similar study with a focus on emerging destinations with limited financial and human resources for traditional marketing campaigns. Second, the present study included only national level DMOs; however, it might be useful to include regional or municipal level DMOs in the analysis. Third, this study covered a systematic random sample of social media postings in a single-year period. Thus, extending the time frame of analysis to several more years might provide more generalizable results. Another limitation involves the four popular social media platforms selected for analysis – a quick examination of official websites of 50 European DMOs reveals that DMOs are beginning to create accounts on *Pinterest*, *Flickr*, *Vimeo*, *Tumblr* and *Weibo* – future research should explore these emerging platforms. Finally, the present study analyzed only social media postings and focused on what DMOs do on social media; while content analysis of these posts provide interesting results, a more qualitative approach involving interviews with DMO managers would offer valuable insight into the understanding of why DMOs use social media in a strategic destination marketing context.

Appendix

See [Table A1](#) and [Table B1](#).

Table A1
List of measures used for the content analysis.

Part A – Official representation	
A1	Presence on related social media platform
A2	Internet address of official social media account
A3	Membership date
Part B – Basic statistics (from start of membership to 12/31/2015)	
B1	Membership period
B2	Number of overall posts (total posts)
B3	Total number of likes
B4	Number of followers
B5	Number of subscribers
B6	Total number of views

(continued on next page)

Table A1 (continued)

Part C – Primary statistics (derived from postings between 1/1/2015– 12/31/2015)

	Content
C1	Number of posts people tagged
C2	Number of people tagged
C3	Number of posts with a hashtag
C4	Number of hashtags used
C5	Hashtags used
C6	Number of posts including a link to a website
C7	Number of links posted
C8	Number of posts including a photo
C9	Number of photos posted
C10	Number of posts including a video
C11	Number of videos posted
	Major theme
C12	Major theme of post *
	Information type
C13	Number of posts providing factual/historical information
C14	Number of posts providing opinion/review
	Engagement
C15	Number of posts that are liked/favored
C16	Number of likes/favorites
C17	Number of posts that are shared/re-tweeted by users
C18	Number of shares/re-tweets
C19	Number of posts with comment/reply
C20	Number of comments/replies
C21	Number of posts that are disliked *
C22	Number of dislikes *
	Interactivity
C23	Number of posts that directly ask questions to users
C24	Number of posts requesting feedback from users
C25	Number of posts requesting photos from users
C26	Number of posts requesting videos from users
	Promotion
C27	Number of posts promoting an event
C28	Number of posts promoting a specific destination within the country
C29	Number of posts promoting an attraction or hotel
C30	Number of posts promoting a restaurant or local cuisine
C31	Number of posts promoting DMO's official website
C32	Number of posts promoting another website
C33	Number of posts promoting another social media outlet of DMO
C34	Name of the promoted social media outlet of DMO
	Customer service
C35	Number of posts responding to criticism
C36	Number of posts responding to compliment
C37	Number of posts responding to an enquiry

Notes:

Measures with an asterisk (*) were developed by the authors, the remaining were adapted from the study of Hays et al. (2013).

Data derived from “Measures in Part B” are from start of membership to 12/31/2015.

1. Measure B2 is available for *Twitter*, *Instagram* and *YouTube*.
2. Measure B3 is available only for *Facebook*.
3. Measure B4 is available for both *Twitter* and *Instagram*.
4. Measures B5 and B6 are available only for *YouTube*.

“Measures in Part C” were used to content-analyze the social media postings during the study period (from 1/1/2015-12/31/2015).

1. All measures in Part C (except for C21 and C22) are available for both *Facebook* and *Twitter*.
2. Measures C6, C7, C17 and C18 are not available for *Instagram*.
3. Measures C8, C9, C12, C17, C18 and C25 are not available for *YouTube*.
4. Measures C21 and C22 are available only for *YouTube*.

Table B1
List of European countries used in the study.

1	Albania ^a
2	Andorra ^b
3	Armenia ^b
4	Austria ^c
5	Azerbaijan ^b
6	Belarus ^b
7	Belgium ^c
8	Bosnia and Herzegovina ^d
9	Bulgaria ^c
10	Croatia ^c
11	Cyprus ^c
12	Czech Republic ^c
13	Denmark ^c
14	Estonia ^c
15	Finland ^c
16	France ^c
17	Georgia ^b
18	Germany ^c
19	Greece ^c
20	Hungary ^c
21	Iceland ^b
22	Ireland ^c
23	Italy ^c
24	Kosovo ^d
25	Latvia ^c
26	Liechtenstein ^b
27	Lithuania ^c
28	Luxembourg ^c
29	Malta ^c
30	Moldova ^b
31	Monaco ^b
32	Montenegro ^a
33	Netherlands ^c
34	Norway ^b
35	Poland ^c
36	Portugal ^c
37	Romania ^c
38	Russia ^b
39	San Marino ^b
40	Serbia ^a
41	Slovakia ^c
42	Slovenia ^c
43	Spain ^c
44	Sweden ^c
45	Switzerland ^b
46	The former Yugoslav Republic of Macedonia ^a
47	Turkey ^a
48	Ukraine ^b
49	United Kingdom ^c
50	Vatican City ^b

Note. Retrieved October 2015, from European Union (http://europa.eu/about-eu/countries/index_en.htm). Countries are listed alphabetically.

^a EU candidate countries.

^b Other European countries.

^c EU member countries.

^d Potential candidate countries for EU.

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